STATUS REPORT

South Sudan — digital transformation and data governance status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The President ordered the full digitisation of public institutions by decree in December 2025, with no published phased roadmap, into a state that has no overarching national digital transformation strategy, no designated lead institution or coordinating machinery for one, and no published strategy documents (2025). The same assessment found no audit or oversight function covering government digital programmes, and nothing published about one.

What passes for a plan is mostly unfinished consultant work. World Bank supervision reporting recorded a Digital Development Road Map and Master Plan, a Government Enterprise Architecture assessment intended to deliver back-end interoperability, and a roadmap for the ICT Authority, none finalised or published (2024). The newest is at the same stage: a National Spectrum Management and 5G Strategy began at an inception workshop in July 2026, run with an external expert team. Where a measure is decided rather than drafted, its terms often go unpublished: the regulator's statement approving the telecom tariff exchange-rate adjustment describes it as phased without numbering the phases and sets no end point for it (June 2026).

Delivery ownership is unstable. Dr Addis Ababa Othow was sworn in as governor of the Bank of South Sudan on 31 July 2026, two days after Johnny Ohisa was dismissed with no reason stated.

The national payment system programme has changed sponsor at least three times in eighteen months: NIPS was announced under Johnny Ohisa in February 2025 and SSIPS launched under Addis Ababa Othow in October 2025, each begun under a different governor from the one now in office.

The largest delivery vehicle was procured outside it. The e-Government concession was awarded without competitive tender, the Ministry of Finance and Planning approving single-sourcing for Crawford Capital in October 2019 and noting "the National Security concern attached to the project", and the UN Commission found the Revenue Authority complicit in the revenue arrangement in what it called clear violation of articles 9 and 10 of the UN Convention against Corruption. The Revenue Authority and the ICT ministry called the engagement lawful, transparent and endorsed by the Council of Ministers in May 2026.

Legislation and regulation

South Sudan acquired its first substantial digital statute on 18 February 2026, when President Salva Kiir signed the Cyber Crimes and Computer Abuse Act 2026 into law, three months after the Revitalized Transitional National Legislative Assembly passed the bill, with amendments, on 25 November 2025. The Act is not confined to policing crime. Operators of critical national infrastructure, with banking and financial services named expressly, must report any cybersecurity incident or data breach to the national authority within 24 hours of detection and submit regular audit reports, enforced by administrative penalties. The enacted text was withheld from journalists at the signing, so the institutions it binds are working from an account of the law rather than the law.

Nothing comparable covers personal data. No data-protection statute is in force, a bill promised to the legislature is not law, and the consumer protection regime that does exist does not address payment services. Mobile money's standing rests not on new legislation but on the central bank's affirmation of it as legal tender under the 2017 Electronic Money Regulation (July 2025). In May 2026 the President signed the legal framework establishing a national ICT Authority to oversee digital regulation, data protection, communication services and emerging-technology coordination.

The identity statutes are older and thinner — the Nationality Act 2011, the Civil Registry Act 2018 and civil registry regulations adopted in December 2024 — and announcements have run ahead of them. Raising ordinary passport validity from five years to ten requires amending the passport act and the approval of both the Council of Ministers and the Transitional National Legislative Assembly, none of which has been done, and ordinary validity remains five years (July 2026). One instrument did complete: South Sudan acceded to the 1954 and 1961 Statelessness Conventions in November 2024. Regulatory power is also exercised outside statute — the National Communication Authority ordered internet service providers to block all social media on 22 January 2025 amid unrest, with journalists and rights defenders working through VPNs.

Data protection

South Sudan has no data protection law and no data protection authority, and therefore no monitoring of compliance and no published enforcement record (2025) — and the bill meant to end that has been sitting finished. Experts completed the drafting of the country's first Data Protection Policy Bill in October 2025, in a process facilitated by Koneta Hub and Paradigm Initiative with the National Communication Authority and civil-society organisations; it would create a Data Protection Commission. The Minister of ICT told parliament in December 2025 that a first Data Protection Bill would be introduced in 2026.

In the meantime protection rests on Article 22 of the 2011 Transitional Constitution, unevenly enforced, and on a Consumer Protection Act 2011 that establishes a Consumer Protection Council with court and complaint enforcement mechanisms but does not address payment services. No data protection authority has been appointed and no law provides for one; the National Communication Authority handles cybersecurity and holds no data protection mandate (2025). For the individual there is no route to see, correct or delete the personal data held about you, no data subject rights in law, and no portal or process for accessing your own national ID record (2024). Nor does the absence stop at the border, since the country imposes no data localisation requirements and no restrictions on foreign access to data held in it (2025).

The state's own appetite for the data is on the record. Amnesty International documented in 2021 that the National Security Service conducts abusive surveillance without legal safeguards, creating a climate of fear, and the single-sourcing of the e-Government concession followed written advice from the then Director-General of the National Security Service's Internal Security Bureau proposing that the contractor work in partnership with the Bureau's ICT Department, because the project aimed to create huge databases and integrate services accessible online. Relief may arrive from outside: East African Community rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection were approved at official level on 24 July 2026, but must still pass the Community's decision-making organs before any partner state adopts them.

Regional collaboration

South Sudan now charges citizens of Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo to enter, while under the July 2026 e-visa fee schedule Tanzanian and Egyptian citizens enter visa-free and South African citizens are visa-free for stays under 30 days, so the new charges fall unevenly across the East African Community. The portal collecting those fees is not even a national build: it runs on the same platform developed for the Government of Kenya, which the UN Commission found the concessionaire neither built nor significantly customised.

Money does not cross the border either. The country's instant payment system connects to no cross-border scheme, it does not participate in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, and connection to the East African Payment System remains an ambition rather than a work stream (2025). At the SSIPS launch, East African Community and African Development Bank representatives cast the system as regional alignment (October 2025), and regional bodies have since agreed a peer review mechanism for macroeconomic surveillance and operational frameworks for the EAC Five-Year Development Strategy 2026/27–2030/31, which apply to South Sudan as a partner state (July 2026).

The instruments that would knit the estate together are all upstream of adoption: rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection were approved at official level on 24 July 2026 but must still pass the Community's decision-making organs before any partner state adopts them, and the East African Community passport remains an announced intention requiring legislation not yet tabled. Where regional work does reach the ground it arrives as donor scaffolding: the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project supports its borrower states through shared digital infrastructure, harmonised regulatory frameworks and digital public goods, and finances the spectrum strategy under an external consultant team. Physical reach is coming faster than legal reach: a 15-year licence effective 16 October 2025 lets MTN's Bayobab build and operate cross-border fibre as part of the East 2 West corridor, and a fibre link from Kenya entered feasibility study from August 2025.

Standards

The one part of the state built to a published international standard is the new interbank payment system, which runs on the ISO 20022 messaging standard. Everywhere else systems are built one at a time. There is no government interoperability framework or data-exchange platform, no data-quality or service-level standards governing exchange between government systems, and no programme to retire legacy systems onto a common standard (2025), and the financial management system does not support a standardised financial classification, so it cannot track spending to programme performance or SDG reporting. South Sudan also has no government open source software policy and no recorded adoption of open source software in the public sector (2025).

Enforcement of technology standards is among the roles announced for the planned ICT Authority, which as at August 2026 had no standards work to its name. The standards South Sudan is most likely to inherit are regional rather than national, and none of them has been adopted: the East African Community's Secure Data Sharing Framework was endorsed at a validation workshop on 25 June 2026, a drafting-stage step. The clearest working exception is procurement, where the electronic government procurement system is in use and publishes both tender notices and awarded contracts (2025).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The law that governs online speech in South Sudan is one the public has not been allowed to read: the full text of the Cyber Crimes and Computer Abuse Act 2026 was withheld from journalists at the signing, so the enacted provisions are not publicly available (February 2026). The ICT ministry has publicly defended the Act against criticism. The regulator has also shown it will act directly against platforms, ordering providers to block all social media during unrest in January 2025.

There is no formal channel for anyone outside government to be heard on digital policy at all: South Sudan has no e-participation or public consultation platform, and no citizen feedback mechanism through which the public can raise complaints about government services (2025). Decisions that reach every subscriber are made and then not explained. Zain South Sudan's own press release calls the tariff measure a phased Telecommunications Tariff Exchange Rate Adjustment and numbers no phases, and the operator published nothing when phase two took effect a month later (June 2026); when the second adjustment took effect at midnight on 26 July 2026, none of the three operators published the revised rates, and the regulator's own approval set no end point for the programme.

The wider conditions for debate have been getting worse rather than better. Freedom of expression and belief is one of South Sudan's ten most deteriorated governance measures, falling 16.7 points over 2014-2023 to 15.6 of 100, 51st of 54 African states, and media freedom scored 30.7 of 100 in 2023, 49th of 54 and down 5.1 points over the decade. Access to the record is no better: what the state discloses and what a citizen can actually obtain both sit near the bottom of the continent (2023), and the country has never held a national election, with nationwide voter registration still being set up in mid-2026.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

South Sudan's Ministry of Information, Communication Technology and Postal Services confirmed in May 2026 a collaboration with Crawford Capital Ltd for e-services research and technical support, presented as following established institutional procedures and Council of Ministers resolutions, and carrying no stated value.

The other agreement on the record is older and Chinese: a preferential loan framework agreement signed in January 2018, alongside the US$248.8 million air-traffic management loan agreement. A framework of that kind sets terms on which lending may follow and commits no money of itself; the money that did follow was committed in the loan agreement beside it, not in the framework.

New investments

The largest single commitment on record in South Sudan's digital estate is China Eximbank's US$248.8 million loan for the Air Traffic Management System project beside Juba International Airport, signed on 25 January 2018, which buys a control centre, a tower and surveillance and navigation systems, built by China Harbour Engineering Company. Most of it was still outstanding at the end of 2022.

Second is the World Bank's US$162 million Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, 2023 to 2028, where South Sudan is a sovereign borrower alongside Somalia, with IGAD and the East African Community borrowing regionally; the figure is the envelope across all of them. It already pays for policy rather than plant: the national spectrum management and 5G strategy launched in July 2026 is financed by it and led by an external consultant team.

European money is smaller and keeps the mobile network powered. Finnfund lent US$5 million in mezzanine finance to CREI for 413 solar-hybrid energy systems at MTN South Sudan's telecom sites (2024) and followed with a second investment backed by the EU's Africa Connected programme (2026). Germany's development ministry has committed EUR 5 million to the East African Community for a regional AI research and training network covering South Sudan (August 2026).

What the state finds from its own hand is approval rather than outlay: a design budget for the second phase of the national fibre-optic programme was approved in June 2025.

Seven digital-sector commitments touching South Sudan are on the record — five direct, two regional programmes naming it among their participants — announced 2016 to 2026, with windows running to 2028. Over that 2016 to 2026 window they come to roughly US$472 million, overwhelmingly debt: the air-traffic loan and the World Bank lending account for US$433 million of it, with three grants, one equity investment and one mezzanine loan making up the rest. Across the same 2016 to 2026 window China is by a wide margin the largest recorded financier at about US$300 million, ahead of the World Bank at US$162 million and Finnfund at US$10 million. The money goes to aviation communications, regional digital integration, teacher training and textbooks, and solar-hybrid power for telecom sites.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

South Sudan's telecom operators were required to bill at an official rate of 4,526 SSP to the dollar while the market ran near 27,000, and in June 2026 the National Communication Authority approved a phased adjustment of tariff exchange rates with no published end point. A second adjustment took effect on 26 July 2026, and none of the three operators published the revised rates. Six months earlier MTN had cut tariffs by a quarter (December 2025), from a starting point of some of the most expensive mobile data in Africa.

Use is rising quickly from a very low base. Active mobile data subscriptions reached 3.60 million in 2025, more than double the 1.77 million of the year before, and mobile connections rose to 4.47 million in 2025 on the regulator's own count. Those are subscriptions rather than people: around a quarter of the population is a unique mobile subscriber and internet use ran at 12 to 16 per cent over 2024-2025, in one of Africa's lowest smartphone-adoption markets. 3G or 4G reaches only a small minority of the population.

Physical reach is a separate problem. The country still has no internet exchange point. A $9 million design budget was approved in June 2025 for phase two of a programme meant to give the country its first national fibre network, and Bayobab holds a 15-year licence effective 16 October 2025 to build national and cross-border fibre on the East 2 West corridor. A cross-border link from Kenya entered feasibility and environmental assessment from August 2025, carrying on to a route to the Indian Ocean announced that October to cut reliance on satellite capacity. Behind it, EARDIP is the only World Bank digital operation covering the country.

Access is also revocable: the regulator ordered providers to block social media for 30 to 90 days in January 2025 amid unrest, three months before MTN took a new 15-year licence. On the 2024 Ibrahim Index, infrastructure is the worst-scoring governance sub-category at 6.3 of 100 and last of 54 African states, internet and computers at 3.0 and mobile communications at 20.1 (2023).

Data Storage

The World Bank is not paying for South Sudan's national data centre: the only Bank digital operation covering the country carries no data-centre workstream in its implementation report of 30 June 2026. Construction in Juba was under way and unfinished as at April 2026 on the ICT minister's own account.

The rules that would say what may go into it do not exist. South Sudan's guidelines on government data hosting, including cloud adoption, remained unpublished as at 16 June 2026, unchanged from their November 2022 baseline and against a target date of April 2028 — so a facility is being built roughly six years ahead of the policy governing what it may hold. Nor does anything push data inward: the country imposes no data localisation requirement and no restriction on foreign access to data held in it (2025).

Outside government there is little to host on. Commercial hosting inside the country is absent, and cloud services reach users from distant regions (2025). Inside it, the registers connect to no government-wide data-exchange platform, and the World Bank-financed regional project is only now building the country's first centralised data-hosting and exchange infrastructure — which places the state's first serious store of its own data, and the first policy governing it, on the same donor timetable.

Energy

South Sudan's mobile network has largely built its own power supply rather than wait for a grid: 490 of MTN South Sudan's 499 telecom sites have been fitted or renovated with solar-hybrid systems under a ten-year energy-as-a-service contract with CREI (2026), work part-financed by Finnfund. That is the shape of the sector: power is procured site by site, by whoever needs it.

The grid behind it barely exists. About 5.4% of the population had access to electricity in 2023, one of the lowest rates in the world, and access ran at roughly 30% in urban areas against about 2% in rural areas (2022). Generation was around 571 GWh in 2023, some 96% of it thermal diesel and under 4% solar photovoltaic, and outages are routine, Juba included (2024). Access to energy scored 1.9 of 100 in 2023, last of 54 African states, up 1.8 points over the decade from a base near zero.

The off-grid route that ought to close the gap is taxed rather than encouraged: an off-grid electrification policy exists with limited implementation, and the small private solar sector faces high taxes on equipment (2023). The consequence is stated plainly by those trying to sell into the country — electricity supply was named the major impediment to South Sudan's digital infrastructure build-out at the September 2025 China-Africa summit. Beyond the towns the deficit reaches past digital services entirely: absent electricity and radio communications, poor roads and minimal logistics constrain policing itself, with community and customary mechanisms substituting for statutory policing in rural and remote areas.

Technical Capacity

The Revenue Authority names a shortage of specialised personnel alongside the ICT-infrastructure deficit as what is holding back tax digitisation (March 2026), and is working with the National Communication Authority on connectivity to close the gap — the people problem stated by the agency that has to solve it, not by an assessor.

What gets built is largely scaffolded from outside. The spectrum and 5G strategy process is financed by the World Bank's regional digital project and led by an external consultant team (July 2026), and the national identity system runs on foreign vendors and external operational support rather than on domestic capacity. The government itself names limited institutional and personnel capacity, weak coordination among agencies and unharmonised procedures as the principal obstacles to its civil registration and identity work (2024), and there is no digital skills strategy and no digital skills programme for public servants feeding the pipeline behind any of it.

Institutional capacity is being reorganised rather than grown. A planned ICT Authority is to manage national digital infrastructure, enforce technology standards and lead public-sector digital transformation under the ICT ministry (May 2026), while effective administration and statistical capacity both sat near the bottom of the African field in 2023 and both fell over the preceding decade.

Cybersecurity

South Sudan now has a binding incident-reporting duty. The Cybercrimes and Computer Misuse Act 2026, signed on 18 February 2026, requires operators of critical national infrastructure — banking and financial services named explicitly — to report any cybersecurity incident or data breach to the national authority within 24 hours of detection and to submit regular audit reports, enforced by administrative penalties. The Assembly passed the bill with amendments on 25 November 2025 and the President signed it into effect three months later.

The same instrument does two jobs at once. Alongside hacking, espionage, cyberterrorism and economic sabotage it criminalises a set of speech and identity offences — fake websites and accounts, false information, online impersonation, hate speech and gender-based harassment. Enforcement is split: the Ministry of Justice interprets and enforces the law, while the ICT ministry coordinates with the National Communication Authority and law enforcement on capacity-building and public awareness (February 2026). The state's own surveillance conduct sits outside that frame: the National Security Service was documented conducting abusive surveillance without legal safeguards (2021), and no data protection authority exists that could review a government system.

Operational capability is newer than the law. The National Communication Authority and the Bank of South Sudan have stood up a Digital Financial Services Security Lab with the ITU to security-test mobile payment applications against international practice (March 2026). Readiness measured before any of this scored 34.38 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, in the index's 'evolving' tier.

DPI

Data Exchange

South Sudan's one working exchange layer moves money between banks rather than data between ministries: the interbank settlement system went live in October 2025, with every licensed bank required to join it by 31 January 2026, and it runs on an ATS+ architecture pairing real-time gross settlement with an automated clearing house on the ISO 20022 messaging standard. The instant payment system scoped separately in February 2025 is designed to sit on top of those rails rather than replace them, aligned with efforts to integrate the clearing and settlement components.

For government data there is no equivalent. The World Bank's 2025 assessment records no interoperability framework and no data-exchange platform, no data-quality or service-level standards governing exchange between government systems, and no programme to retire legacy systems onto a common standard. There is no standalone exchange or interoperability strategy either, the subject being carried as a sub-component of the World Bank-financed Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, which runs to 2028 and is only now building the country's first centralised data-hosting and exchange infrastructure. No law governs the sharing of data between government bodies.

The systems that would connect are not connected. The tax register takes a national ID number keyed in by hand, with no automated verification against the identity system. The civil register is tied neither to the identity system nor to any exchange. The electoral register is compiled with no technology at all. The business register exchanges no company information with other public agencies. Health runs DHIS2 in parallel between the Ministry of Health, WHO and UNICEF, education three separate platforms, social protection a donor platform managed by UNOPS.

A government enterprise architecture assessment meant to deliver back-end interoperability between agency systems had been neither finalised nor published as at 2024. Regionally, the East African Community's Secure Data Sharing Framework, which covers all partner states, reached validation in Dar es Salaam on 25 June 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Since January 2026 the personal identity card, the Butaka Shakhsia, has been required for banking, land transactions and court processes for adults aged 18 and over — a requirement laid on a population of whom around 20% held a national identity document as at 2022. The card does nothing digitally: it carries a 2D barcode and a machine-readable zone but has no online authentication capability, and no eKYC or verification service is connected to the national ID database, so identity checks stay physical and in person. Behind it sits no national digital identity system, only fragmented biometric databases held separately by the civil registry directorate, UNHCR, WFP and IOM.

Issuance is governed by consignments rather than by capacity. The directorate held 380,000 personal ID cards and roughly 35,000 nationality certificates when it resumed issuance in January 2026 after a shortage across every document category; deliveries through June and July 2026 left it holding 37,500 regular passport booklets and close to 200,000 nationality cards, enough to sustain issuance to December 2026. Greater Yei began distributing more than 4,000 cards in July 2026.

The money comes from outside the state budget: a UNHCR and European Union partnership funded more than 17,400 cards issued from the start of 2024, concentrated in the Central Equatoria return counties of Morobo, Lainya, Yei and Kajo-Keji. Documents are charged for: SSP 30,000 for a nationality certificate under the 2024/25 schedule, and more than SSP 50,000 for a national identity card, with a passport at US$100 as at July 2026.

The estate rests on the Nationality Act 2011, the Civil Registry Act 2018 and the Civil Registry Regulations adopted in December 2024. The identity card is issued only to adults, while the nationality certificate is available at any age and only about 10% of roughly 12 million people held one as at December 2025. Refugees carry separate cards issued by the Commission for Refugee Affairs under the Refugee Act 2012, 14,653 of them between January and June 2024, the national ID being reserved for nationals. The civil register underneath all of it is largely paper-based.

Digital Payments and Fintech

South Sudan's first electronic interbank payment system went live on 10 October 2025, settling between banks rather than between people: SSIPS is wholesale settlement infrastructure, with mobile-money and fintech onboarding still being solicited at the launch. Thirteen commercial banks were connected by November 2025, and the Bank of South Sudan operates the national payment system itself rather than delegating it to a scheme operator.

The National Instant Payment System is a separate and earlier programme, and remains a project: a February 2025 partnership between the Bank of South Sudan and AfricaNenda, announced under governor Johnny Ohisa Damian, scoped an implementation roadmap, capacity-building and bank-telco interoperability following a 2023 proof of concept.

Retail payment runs on mobile money, which the Bank of South Sudan affirmed as legal tender in July 2025 under the 2017 Electronic Money Regulation, making refusal to accept it a punishable offence. The user base is thin: around 6% of adults hold an account at a bank or mobile money provider and mobile money penetration is below 1%, the lowest rate recorded among Global Findex economies (2021), and more than 90% of the economy was cash-based as at July 2025. The central bank's Strategic Plan 2023-27 targets 30% mobile money usage among adults by 2027. Nothing crosses the border on the state rails: South Sudan does not participate in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, and connection to the East African Payment System stayed an ambition as at 2025.

The rails carrying government money are privately operated and take a rent. A November 2020 contract makes Crawford Capital the Revenue Authority's e-Tax collector with a legal entitlement to 2% of all digitally assessed taxation, against the 0.5% commercial banks receive for physically collecting and transporting cash revenue; its payments subsidiary levies a further US$20.16 on a US$100 visa; and from late 2023 banks were instructed to deposit non-oil revenue collections into accounts controlled by the company rather than into Revenue Authority accounts as the law requires. Fees for passports and national identity documents have had to be paid digitally rather than in cash since January 2026.

Registries

The register South Sudan has pushed furthest since 2025 is of farmers rather than of people: the Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security and FAO launched a Farmers' E-Registry and a Co-operatives E-Registry in April 2025, carrying farmer and cooperative records and an e-voucher module for agricultural inputs, with roll-out under way across all ten states and the three administrative areas. There is no operational population register: the nationwide civil registration exercise launched in 2019 under the Civil Registry Act 2018 is event-based rather than a continuously maintained record.

Civil registration has gone backwards where it was digital. Its only digital element, a birth-notification system run with the Ministry of Health, has been non-operational since 2018, and no digital death, marriage or divorce registration exists. The registry works mainly in towns, leaving the rural majority unreached, and birth registration completeness is among the lowest in Africa.

The business register is the most digitised. An online Business Registration Service has run at the Ministry of Justice since 2023, and the World Bank's 2025 assessment finds name verification, registration and certificate issuance digitised while beneficial ownership updates and online fee payment are not. It joins to nothing: the assessment scores zero for exchange of company information among public agencies and records no interoperability with the land registry, and a business must be validated by the Ministry of Justice before the Revenue Authority's platform will issue a taxpayer identification number, a manual step rather than an automated one.

Land is barely registered. There is no operational national digital land register: registration passed from the judiciary to the Ministry of Lands only recently, and the ministry was still designing a digital registry to replace manual, largely Arabic-language paper records as at mid-2025, and the draft national land policy describes largely manual registries in Juba, Wau and Renk alone, with no national cadastre. The electoral register is compiled with no technology, and no national election has ever been held, with nationwide voter registration still being set up as at mid-2026. There is no standard postal or address-code system and no government-run digital address register.

Sectoral management information systems

South Sudan had no human resource management system for the public service and no government payroll system as at 2025, and is running a US$15m World Bank-backed biometric registration of civil servants to purge ghost workers, the data held on a Ministry of Finance server. It runs in three phases — national institutions, then the states, then the organised forces, the last launched in June 2026, and stands as a silo with no route into any exchange layer.

Tax administration has statutory teeth: filing through the eTax platform has been mandatory for all taxpayers since 1 July 2021. Its reach is small — around 62,000 registered individual taxpayers and around 21,000 organisational taxpayers as at 2026 — and eTax and eCustoms remain separate systems, with the Revenue Authority's own September 2025 management review flagging the need for integration between them, against no customs management system and no exchange of customs data with other government systems as at 2025.

Health and education both run on paper. A 2024/25 maturity assessment rates the health information system at 40.5% overall and at 37% for data and information communication and use, and rural primary health units keep paper registers and handwritten monthly summaries that are physically carried to County Health Departments for transcription into DHIS2. Three parallel education systems — the ministry's own, a donor-funded attendance monitor and a separate refugee EMIS — use inconsistent indicator definitions and are linked neither to each other nor to other government systems, and rural primary schools capture attendance and enrolment in handwritten classroom registers aggregated by hand.

Social protection is run for the state rather than by it. There is no unified national social registry; a programme-specific biometric beneficiary system has run under World Bank-financed safety nets since 2014 and authenticated 100% of programme payments by 2024, managed by UNOPS as a standalone donor platform and running its own biometric registration and deduplication rather than the national ID. A social insurance system is in use but does not interoperate with other government systems and does not use the national identification number.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Almost everything a citizen or business can transact online with the South Sudanese state runs through one private concession. Crawford Capital Ltd, through its payments subsidiary Capital Pay Ltd, has been the exclusive provider of e-Government Services since a 16 November 2019 contract with the ICT ministry, covering trade permits, visas, tax payments, customs and work permits, and the contract gives the contractor 75% of the eServices profit share against the ministry's 25%, revised upward from the 65% the initial contract indicated. The platform is not its own work: the e-visa portal runs on the 'e-Citizen' platform Webmasters Kenya built for the Government of Kenya, and the UN Commission found Crawford neither built nor significantly customised it.

The visa is the one service genuinely completed online: applicants apply on the portal, pay online and download the approved document before travel, against a stated 72-hour processing time, and fees revised on 20 July 2026 charge citizens of Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo USD 50, and citizens of Somalia, Burundi and Nigeria USD 100. Elsewhere, the eServices platform gives citizens and businesses a single sign-on account for business registration, trade licensing, and revenue and customs services, paying by mobile money, card or bank transfer, and an electronic procurement system was in use as at 2025, publishing both tender notices and awarded contracts.

The public financial management core is narrower than its presence suggests: an integrated financial management information system was in use as at 2025 on commercial off-the-shelf software covering treasury and budget preparation, but it covers central government only, supports no standardised financial classification and cannot track spending to programme performance or SDG reporting, and a treasury single account is still under implementation rather than operational. South Sudan ranked 192nd of 193 countries on the UN E-Government Development Index 2024, with a score of 0.1191.

Of the 32 headline GovTech indicators the World Bank assessed for South Sudan in its 2025 update, seven record a system or law in place, one records implementation in progress, and 24 record the item as absent.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

South Sudan's integrated financial management information system covers central government only and does not extend to sub-national government (2025), so states and counties sit outside the one system that would carry public money through a digital record. The wider pattern is the same: digital systems are concentrated in Juba and operate at national level only, with rural counties effectively excluded (2025).

Where the local tier touches the digital state at all it does so as a transcription point rather than a user — county health departments key paper returns from the clinics below them into the national health platform (2025), and the registers a local administration would draw on, the civil registry among them, reach the towns and stop (2024). Rural populations were scored at the lowest assessed level for representation and participation in 2023, where they had been for the decade before.

Rural digital data capture

South Sudan's rural economy scored 10.7 of 100 in 2023, 45th of 54 African states and down 8.9 points across the preceding decade — the steepest fall of any of the sixteen sub-categories the Ibrahim Index measures. Over the same period rural land and water access dropped to 13.0 of 100, and support to the rural economy to 19.3, both in the bottom ten on the continent.

The systems that would do the capturing are not there to do it: South Sudan's digital systems are concentrated in Juba and operate at national level only, with border regions and rural counties effectively excluded and network coverage outside the capital intermittent (2025). Rural electricity access runs far below the urban rate (2022), and the off-grid policy that would close that gap has seen limited implementation, with a small private solar sector and high taxes on solar equipment (2023).

So the facilities record on paper. Rural health units keep patient data in paper registers and handwritten monthly summaries, physically carried to county health departments for transcription into the national platform (2025), and rural primary schools keep handwritten classroom registers aggregated by hand for state and national reporting (2026). Policing beyond the towns operates without electricity or radio communications, on poor roads and minimal logistics, with community and customary mechanisms standing in for the statutory kind.

What has moved has moved outward from the centre and only lately. The agriculture ministry and FAO launched farmers' and co-operatives e-registries in April 2025, with roll-out under way beyond Juba, and national identity cards began to be collected in the Greater Yei region in July 2026. The civil registry still operates mainly in towns (2024), and the regulator has named rural connectivity among its priorities for 2026.

Technology

AI

The artificial-intelligence activity that reaches South Sudan is regional rather than national: Germany's development ministry has funded an East African Community network for artificial-intelligence research and training covering the partner states, carrying an EAC artificial-intelligence strategy for 2025-2028 and digital skills training, and South Sudanese universities took part in the 2025 pilot of the AI4EAC Innovation Challenge, a student competition run across the eight member countries.

Nationally the position is one of intent. South Sudan's citizen-facing government services carried no artificial intelligence or chatbot in 2025, and the government's own account of what AI would take is a list of preconditions rather than a programme: at the Global AI Summit in Kigali in April 2025 the ICT undersecretary named infrastructure, a quality data centre and skilled people as the three prerequisites, without which the country will hardly benefit. The fibre-optic build is framed as the first of them.

The regional instruments are themselves still proposals. An artificial-intelligence policy roadmap for the eight partner states was explored at a regional science and technology conference in March 2026, and the EAC central bank governors' call to harmonise regulation of artificial intelligence and digital finance had not been taken up by member states as at July 2026.

ICT Industry

The national fibre backbone is being built by the infrastructure arm of a foreign operator: MTN's Bayobab holds a licence effective October 2025 to build and operate national and cross-border fibre, IP transit and leased circuits and is building the national backbone with NCT South Sudan as at March 2026. MTN itself holds a renewed mobile operator licence granted in April 2025 and brought eSIM service to the market in January 2025. The same pattern holds where government is the customer: the largest financing commitment on record in the country's digital estate went to an air traffic management system beside Juba International Airport, financed by China Eximbank and delivered by a Chinese contractor, and the mining and petroleum licence cadastre was a vendor system.

Behind that there is very little domestic supply. Business and competition regulation scored 16.3 of 100 in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states and down over the preceding decade, with economic diversification ranked at the same place in the same measure, and technology startups are very few. The state's own interface to the sector is thin but not empty: company formation and business registration are listed among the services on the national government portal as at 2025.

Innovation ecosystem

South Sudan is not among the 133 economies covered by WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024, its data coverage being insufficient for inclusion — a gap in the machinery of innovation as much as in its measurement. There is no startup or innovation law, and no state programme providing startup financing or small and medium enterprise support for the digital sector as at 2025, and no public-sector innovation programme, laboratory or fund, nor any stated mechanism for public-private collaboration on digital public services. The cheapest route in is closed too: government has no open source software policy and no recorded public-sector adoption.

What exists sits outside the state, donor-built or self-organised. The University of Juba's UNIPOD, a US$1.2 million innovation facility, opened in 2023 with UNDP support. At least three AfriLabs member hubs — Konetahub, Ataka Hub and Junub Open Space — were operating in 2023 alongside Scenius Hub in Juba, and Juba has an active Google Developer Group, profiled in 2021, one of the few organised developer communities in the country. Around them, technology startups are very few and venture capital activity is not visible as at 2025.

Capacity

Literacy

Equality in education scores 3.8 of 100, last of all 54 African states, and education quality 1.9 of 100, 51st of 54 (2023) — that is the schooling on top of which anyone in South Sudan is asked to read and work a digital system.

Education as a whole is the second-weakest of the country's governance sub-categories, at 10.6 of 100 and 53rd of 54, and its strongest component, enrolment, stands at 25.9 and 45th of 54 after a rise of 3.8 points over the decade (2023).

What the school system records about itself is largely still on paper: rural primary schools capture attendance, enrolment and administrative data in handwritten classroom registers, aggregated by hand for state and national reporting (2026). Above them sit parallel education data systems — the ministry's own, a donor-funded attendance platform and a separate system for refugees — using indicator definitions that do not match, linked neither to each other nor to other government systems (2025). A reader who wants to know how many children are in school, and whether they can read, is asking a question the country's own reporting is not yet built to answer.

Training and skills

South Sudan has no digital skills strategy, no digital skills programme for public servants, and no digital skills programme reaching citizens or schools (2025). Nothing the state runs teaches anyone to use the systems it is building.

What teaching there is runs through a small tertiary pipeline: at least three institutions offer computer science and information technology degrees — the University of Juba's School of Computer Science and Information Technology, established in 2009, Ayii University and Starford International University (2025). Outside the universities the organised technical community is thin, with Juba's Google Developer Group among the few of them, profiled by Google in 2021.

The training money in prospect is regional rather than national: Germany's development ministry is funding an East African Community artificial intelligence research and training network, with digital skills work for young people across partner states including South Sudan (August 2026).

At the far end of the pipeline the state offers nothing to meet it: there is no state-run employment or jobs-matching platform (2025), so what graduates the universities produce, they place themselves.

Research institutions

The University of Juba's UNIPOD, a US$1.2 million innovation facility, was launched in 2023 with UNDP support, and is the clearest piece of research and innovation infrastructure the country has stood up in recent years.

It rests on a narrow base: at least three institutions teach computer science and information technology, the oldest of them the University of Juba's own school, established in 2009 (2025). Beyond that, the country takes part in knowledge produced elsewhere rather than producing it — South Sudanese universities joined the 2025 pilot of a regional artificial intelligence innovation challenge run across eight East African Community countries, a second edition of which carries prize funding and new industry and university partners (2026).

Inclusion

Access to services

Equal access to public services scored 8.2 of 100 in 2023, last of 54 African states, though up 4.6 points over the decade. The gate has tightened rather than loosened: since January 2026 the Directorate of Civil Registry has required the personal identity card, the Butaka Shakhsia, for banking, land transactions and court processes, where a minority of the population held one as at 2022. For schooling and employment the card is accepted rather than required, precisely because a mandatory rule would exclude the majority.

Obtaining the document is itself the barrier. The civil registry operates mainly in towns and is not integrated, leaving most citizens in rural settings unreached by it, and both the passport and the identity card sit behind fees, as does a nationality certificate, on top of the blood tests and photographs an application requires. Non-nationals are on a separate track: refugees hold refugee identity cards issued by the Commission for Refugee Affairs under the Refugee Act 2012, the national card being reserved for South Sudanese nationals, while documentation for returnees, displaced people and those at risk of statelessness runs through donor-supported projects and issuance campaigns in the Central Equatoria return counties rather than a standing entitlement.

Online delivery exists but reaches few: a national portal offers services that can be completed online, not only described, against the connection rate above. Payments repeat it: account holding was the lowest recorded among Global Findex economies in 2021, the economy overwhelmingly cash and outside the banking system as at July 2025, and the national instant payment system still a roadmap rather than a live rail.

The price of reaching it rose twice in 2026. Phase one of the tariff exchange-rate adjustment took effect on 26 June 2026, adding about 70 SSP a minute on top of an existing 181 SSP baseline for a one-minute call; MTN South Sudan, Zain South Sudan and Digitel then implemented a second adjustment at midnight on 26 July 2026 in a joint statement, and none of the three published the revised rates. Together they undid MTN's December 2025 tariff cut within seven months.

Digital divides

Equal socioeconomic opportunity is one of South Sudan's ten most improved governance measures, rising 12.9 points over the decade to 2023 to reach 16.8 of 100, 50th of 54 African states. That is the shape of most inclusion gains here: genuine movement from a base so low that the country still sits at or near the foot of the same continental table on mobile communications and on internet and computers.

An estimated 1.90 million people were online at the start of 2025, 15.7 per cent of a population of 12.1 million. The gap between that and the reach of the network is now the more telling divide: mobile coverage reached most of the population by 2026, but South Sudan was among Africa's lowest-adoption smartphone markets in 2025 and mobile data among the most expensive on the continent (November 2025). What is available and what is used are separated by the handset and the price of a gigabyte rather than by the mast.

Geography draws the sharper line. Electricity reached a minority of urban households and almost none of the rural population in 2022; as at 2025 digital systems were concentrated in Juba and operated at national level only, leaving border regions and rural counties effectively excluded and coverage outside the capital intermittent; and within the state's own service systems, facility-level electronic health records were concentrated away from rural primary care in the same year.

The regulator has taken the point at the level of stated intent: the National Communication Authority set rural connectivity, child online protection and regulatory reform through ITU and East African Community cooperation as its priorities for 2026, with access still heavily concentrated in Juba. Beneath all of it the schooling base is the weakest constraint of all: education quality and equality in education both sit at the bottom of the African table, which is where any broadening of who can use a digital service has to start.

Data

National statistics

South Sudan's ability to count itself has gone backwards rather than forwards: the capacity of its statistical system scored 21.4 out of 100 in 2023, 51st of 54 African states and down 10.4 points over the preceding decade.

The World Bank's assessment locates the weakness. South Sudan scored under 20 per cent on both data services and data sources in 2023, against 50-69 per cent on data products: the machinery that gathers the raw material and gets results out to the people who need them is in worse shape than the statistics themselves. Behind that sits a survey programme that has largely stopped. One household survey has been run in the past ten years, and no agricultural, business, health or labour force survey at all, leaving no recent evidence on employment, health service use or the farm economy. A population census has been held within the last twenty years; an agricultural census and an economic or business census have not.

Administrative records cannot stand in for the missing surveys, because the administrative systems are themselves on paper. Rural health facilities keep handwritten registers that are physically carried to county offices for transcription into the national DHIS2 platform, primary schools aggregate handwritten classroom registers by hand for state and national education reporting, civil registration runs on manual forms and handwritten registers, and the government's financial management system cannot track spending to programme performance.

The National Bureau of Statistics does run a Data Portal with an API for programmatic access and a National Data Archive holding census and survey microdata (2025), and with IGAD it has agreed data-sharing protocols among contributing ministries for migration and displacement statistics during 2025.

Where a headline number does exist, the state is not always its author: the regulator and ICT ministry's own technology-sector timeline of July 2025 reproduced the user and penetration figures circulated by commercial compilers rather than measuring separately. The 2024 Ibrahim Index, for its part, carries no data at all for South Sudan on nineteen of its ninety-six indicators, every public-perception measure among them.

Open data

None of South Sudan's statistics on ICT and digital, government finance, trade or labour are published as open data with usable coverage, all four scoring zero out of ten in the 2024 Open Data Inventory, and the same zero attaches to education facilities and outcomes, health facilities, crime and justice, food security, agriculture, energy, pollution and land use. A zero is a verdict on publication, not on collection: it says a user cannot obtain the data in open, usable form from the official sites, not that no part of government holds it.

Thirteen of the twenty-three categories assessed for South Sudan in 2024 score zero out of ten, and only one exceeds five.

That one is money and banking, at 6.0 out of 10 in 2024, followed by poverty and income at 5.0 and population, national accounts and price statistics at 4.5 — roughly the set a central bank or a donor programme needs, and little past it.

There is no national open data portal (2025), and no national data governance body, no data strategy and nothing published about how government data is governed (2025). A right to information law is on the statute book, but there is no online route by which a member of the public can request records, and no online publication of the records themselves. Both halves of that show in the continental comparison: disclosure of public records scored 13.0 out of 100 in 2023, 46th of 54, and accessibility of public records 7.8, 49th of 54, so what the state puts out and what a citizen can actually get hold of both sit near the bottom of Africa.

The reflex extends to the law itself. The full text of the Cyber Crimes and Computer Abuse Act was withheld from journalists at its signing in February 2026, and nothing is published on how government systems share data among themselves.

Use of satellite data

No national space or geospatial data policy had been adopted in South Sudan as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

No American public financing commitment, hyperscaler infrastructure or standing bilateral digital agreement was in place in South Sudan as at August 2026.

China activities

China is by a wide margin the largest external financier of South Sudan's digital estate, ahead of the World Bank and every other source on the record.

That position rests mainly on one project. China Eximbank's loan for the Air Traffic Management System beside Juba International Airport, signed in January 2018 and still the largest single commitment recorded in the country's digital estate, pays for an air traffic management centre, a new control tower and operations building, and surveillance, navigation and communication systems, with China Harbour Engineering Company as the engineering contractor. A preferential loan framework agreement between the two governments was signed the same day, on 25 January 2018.

The second channel is education. Chinese government grants have funded two phases of an Educational Technical Cooperation Project with the Government of South Sudan, the first running from June 2016 to November 2018 and delivering course design, printed textbooks, training in China for South Sudanese teachers and the construction of training centres. An ICT teacher training centre equipped under that project was handed over in Juba in July 2017, a month of ICT training was run in February 2018, and the ICT infrastructure and training component completed in September 2018. A second phase was agreed by exchange of letters on 18 June 2020.

The vendor presence is thinner than the lending. Huawei used the China-Africa Cooperation Summit in September 2025 to signal interest in South Sudan's digital architecture, including the national data hub and smart-city plans, a return to a country it had largely left after 2014, and to press Chinese and African partners for more digital-infrastructure financing rather than to offer any.

EU activities

The most active European position in South Sudan is a Finnish one, and it is in power rather than in networks. Finnfund's US$5 million mezzanine loan to Communication and Renewable Energy Infrastructure (CREI) financed the installation, operation and maintenance of 413 solar-hybrid energy systems for MTN South Sudan's telecom sites (2024), and a follow-on investment in the same company came backed by the European Fund for Sustainable Development Plus under the EU's Africa Connected programme (2026).

European money also pays for South Sudanese identity documents, in a national ID system financed principally from outside the state budget: a UNHCR and European Union partnership paid for more than 17,400 national identity cards issued in 2024.

The newest European commitment reaches South Sudan through a regional body rather than directly. Germany's development ministry BMZ has committed EUR 5 million to the East African Community to set up a regional artificial intelligence research and training network across partner states including South Sudan, funding an EAC AI strategy for 2025-2028 and digital skills for 50,000 young people (August 2026), with no country allocation attached.

Beyond finance, the European footprint sits in documents that have yet to appear. An EU-funded e-government strategy is in preparation under the Ministry of Information, Communication Technology and Postal Services, alongside a South Sudan Digital Development Road Map (2024).

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based operator held a financing commitment, infrastructure stake or standing agreement in South Sudan's digital estate as at August 2026.

India activities

India held no financing commitment, infrastructure contract, standing agreement or training programme in South Sudan's digital estate as at August 2026.

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